

NO!

**THE ART AND
ACTIVISM OF
COMPLAINING**

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You might recognize yourself in someone else's complaint or you might recognize an institution. A reviewer of my monograph on complaint wrote, "I kept thinking, 'She's writing about me, about my former institution.' It made it even more painful that she wasn't." It can be more painful to hear yourself and your institution in other people's complaints because it tells you there is more *to* what you experienced; more people, more violence, more pain.

That we *don't know* the continuity of other people's complaints with our own is why we need to share our stories. Complaints are mostly confidential; they are made behind closed doors. In listening to each other's stories of complaint, we put our *ears to the door*, overhearing conversations that would otherwise be kept secret ("it makes me ... feel as if you've been listening at my door").

Complaints, once made, have their own lives. But their lives remain entangled with ours. I use the term *complaint biography* to describe this entanglement. I kept noticing how people would begin by telling me about a specific complaint they had made, the one that had brought them to be in conversation with me, but would then digress, telling me about other complaints they had or had not made before. I learned something about complaint

from this tendency to digress. A story of one complaint ends up as a story of another because their lives are as messy as ours. I invite each of you reading this book to put your ear to your own past, to think about your own complaints, those you made, those you didn't make, so they can join the stories collected here. Do you remember the first complaint you made? I remember mine. I was at school. School had always been a difficult space for me; the lessons seemed to be more about the power of those who taught them than the content of what they taught. In primary school, I had a teacher who would repeatedly hit students on their hands with his ruler. He singled out those of us who did not give him the respect he did not deserve. I remember another teacher who would insist she was right even when she was wrong. I was being taught that authority meant the right to be wrong.

Mostly, I did not complain about the teachers, just cataloged instances in the firmness of my resolve about who I did not want to become. But there was one time I did complain. It was after a physical-education class. The teacher did not think we were paying attention to her properly. She suspected some students were causing a disruption. Some of us probably were. Her punishment was to cancel the whole class. We were sent from an outdoor sports field to the library and told to write essays about sports instead. I happened to prefer the new activity to the canceled one. I wrote an essay on horse riding; the books piling up around me, shiny pictures of horses. I could hear the sounds of annoyance, shuffled papers, and sensed sideways glances, directed at those of us who had deprived others of an activity they would have enjoyed. I am not sure who was being disruptive on that day. I am not sure anyone was sure. So, the sideways glances fell on those assumed to be the likely cause.

I felt them fall on me. I knew I was supposed to feel ashamed. And I did. I also felt a sense of indignation. The annoyance of my classmates helped me to understand how discipline is achieved by encouraging people to adopt the attitude that those who disobey are in the way, stopping them from getting what they want. It was not just that the other students were *not* annoyed with the teacher but that they identified with her, sharing her annoyance

with the students who were disruptive. I did not identify with the teacher because I thought she was wrong. So, in a paragraph in the middle of the essay, I made a complaint. I wrote that it was unjust to punish everyone for the misdemeanors, whether real or perceived, of a few.

The teacher read the essay and found the complaint. I was sent to the headmistress's office. When I think back to this experience, my first experience of complaining, or at least the first complaint I remember making, it is the feeling I recall mostly, how it *felt* to be sent to the headmistress's office, which was not just, at least in the consciousness of students, an actual room but a dreaded destination. Complaints can be a story of where we end up, those dreaded destinations, offices with closed doors, the conversations that happen inside of them; atmospheres stern, solemn. The headmistress asked me to explain my actions, perhaps also myself. I said that I had complied with the punishment, but that I thought it was wrong and that I had a right to say what was wrong. She said I would not be allowed to go to an art class unless I apologized to the teacher. I really wanted to go to the art class; it was where I could best express myself.

And so, I apologized to the teacher. And then, I was allowed to go to that class. I was learning how compliance works; we are told to protect our relationship to those with authority, or to be willing to repair any damage to those relationships, to get where we want to go.

Looking back, I am struck by how I inserted my critique of the teacher's action into the essay. My complaint was *almost* hidden in an act of compliance. Perhaps I did not expect anyone to find it. Perhaps the point was just to express myself, to put on paper what I felt and thought. Or perhaps I did not have the confidence to be more direct, to confront the teacher. That we express our complaints obliquely or indirectly, not quite coming out with them, is a consequence of a central problem addressed in this book: Those receiving our complaints are often who we are complaining about.

And by *those* I am not just referring to a person or persons but to institutions. Complaint procedures designed by institutions seem to be used primarily to protect them and those whom they value most, their most senior employees. This problem of institutions handling complaints made about them is the origin of the *ombudsman*. That word was borrowed from Sweden, the first country to appoint an independent official to investigate complaints made against government officials and agencies. The existence of an ombudsman does not resolve the problem of complaints remaining internal to organizations for the many complaints that don't make it to one.

We can complain at work without filling in forms or addressing institutions. And it is because complaints can be made in so many different ways that it is not always clear whether an action is a complaint. You might think of yourself as making one—perhaps you complained about a sexist or racist comment made during a meeting—and be laughed off as if you don't really mean it. Or you might think of yourself as not complaining but be heard as if you are—perhaps you answered the question “Is that Miss or Mrs.?” with a polite but firm “Ms.,” or asked a colleague not to keep calling you “darling.” Requests for change, including in the informal ways we address each other, are often heard as being negative or mean-spirited.

In this book, I use the term *complainer* rather than the more legalistic term *complainant* because of how it is filled by negativity as well as feeling. The negativity of a complaint is directed outward: It is how we say no to an existing state of affairs or refuse to accept things as they are. But when you become a complainer, negativity is assumed to come from within. The word *complainer* is thus rather akin to *killjoy*; in fact, *killjoy* is typically listed as a synonym for *complainer*. The killjoy and the complainer are both used to diagnose a problem as being one of character: as if you complain *because* you are a complainer or kill joy *because* you are joyless.

I have written about killjoys, specifically feminist killjoys, many times before. In *The Promise of Happiness*, published in 2010, they had a chapter of their own. In *The Feminist Killjoy Handbook*, published thirteen years

later, I gave them a whole book. I began that book by setting a scene: I am at a table with my family, having polite conversations, trying hard not to react to sexist comments made by my father. Invariably I would fail and end up saying I had a problem with what he said. And then, the atmosphere would change, becoming tense, as if I had created a problem rather than pointed one out. I heard these words often: “Sara, another dinner ruined!”

If I was a complainer at school, I was a killjoy at home, not quite willing or able to be silent or compliant in order to keep the peace with a patriarch or to sustain the illusion that all was well. I did not call myself a feminist killjoy back then. The feminist killjoy is, in fact, a stereotype of feminists: those miserable feminists who make misery their mission. Misery is not our mission. So why claim the name? A conversation I had with Patricia, a professor, gives clues as to why. Patricia had supported students who made a collective complaint about sexual harassment by another lecturer in her department. She explains how their complaint was framed: “You feminists come along, and you just spoil the fun.” We claim the name *feminist killjoy* not because we intend to cause misery. That’s the stereotype. We claim that name because if doing our work causes misery, that is what we might need to cause.

I now think of becoming a feminist killjoy as another thread in my complaint biography. *No!* can thus be read as a companion text to *The Feminist Killjoy Handbook* not least because the complainer and the killjoy are themselves companions; their stories, our stories, tangled together. Claiming the name *feminist killjoy* means being willing to be heard as a complainer, heard as negative for not wanting to reproduce the same things, heard as destructive for the same reason.

To complain is to be a *killjoy at work*. I mean by this: Complaining is both a job we end up doing and what we learn on the job. That’s why, in this book, I make use of some **killjoy truths** and **killjoy commitments** introduced in *The Feminist Killjoy Handbook*, as well as offer some new ones. They appear throughout as sentences

written in bold. **Killjoy truths** are what we learn from our efforts to change institutions. They are flashes of insight, which often come from encountering resistance to change (and that can include our own resistance). **Killjoy commitments** are what we are willing to do to bring about change. We might need to be willing to say no, whatever the consequences.

You would be right to ask: *No* to what? *No* can be a simple utterance, an answer to a question, yes or no. But, as you will hear in the chapters that follow, saying no within an institution, or to one, is no simple matter. When we say no to institutions and the conduct they enable, often in contradiction with their own policies, and are called *killjoys* or *complainers*, that *no* is dismissed as deriving from ill intent. We learn on the job how hard it is to say no or how hard it is made to say it. We learn from what comes back at us when we say it. We hear how we are not heard.

To be heard as complaining is not to be heard.

If you became a complainer in one situation, you might become rather cautious about complaining in another. Let me return to Patricia's experience. She told me what happened in her next job when she tried to complain about sexism and misogyny she experienced at an offsite conference. She made an informal complaint, but when nothing happened, she let it drop. "It does shake you," Patricia said. "You think, 'Oh, I am making a fuss.'" She turned that worry into a question: "Should I make a fuss?" She worried all the more because she had "already made a massive fuss at my previous institution." Still, she regrets not pursuing it: "That's why I am so cross now, I didn't say anything."

If you can regret not complaining, you can regret complaining. One student, Andrea, told me about her expe-

rience of making a complaint about harassment and bullying by a professor in her department. Her complaint did not get anywhere. She said, “Maybe you could make an argument that somehow it is therapeutic to air one’s woes, but, to be perfectly frank, I haven’t found it therapeutic at all and it continues, and I am finding it difficult to move on with my life.” It is hard to put a complaint behind you when what you complained about continues. Experiences of complaining or not complaining can have ripple effects on our sense of ourselves. But not just on our sense of ourselves. Andrea left the institution with a sharp critique of how it “weeded out anyone who thinks a bit differently.”

A complaint biography can thus be about our changing relationship to institutions. That’s why my first complaint (or at least the first one I remember making) was not the beginning but in the middle of my complaint biography. What led me to complain at that moment was more structure than event, how I had come to feel alienated from the school as one of only a few students of color. All my teachers at the school were white; in fact, I have never had a teacher who wasn’t. I was not only schooled in whiteness by teachers. When I answered my peers’ questions about why I had a “funny” surname by explaining my father was from Pakistan, I was left feeling it was “funny” to come from somewhere else.⁶ Their parents would make anxious references to color; I remember one saying, “Well, at least you must tan easily, dear,” another saying it was such a shame I was not given more lines in *The King and I* (that Orientalist play set in Thailand) because I “looked the part.” Yes, these were little comments, not worth complaining about. But adding up, they might have had something to do with why I eventually complained, albeit about something else.

As a university student, I complained more. I complained about how our courses were organized around a narrow body of work (I called it *all white men until week ten*). I did not use formal procedures but complained informally through what I said in and out of seminars. I probably became known as a complainer during this time.

And there were consequences, as you would probably expect: More resources were given to my peers who had more positive relationships with the senior people in the department.

My first academic job was in Women's Studies. It felt rather like a feminist bubble. I had less to complain about because we were creating our own feminist courses, our own resources. When I became codirector of the Institute for Women's Studies in the year 2000, I began to attend more university committees. Some of them took place in the top room of the fanciest building on campus. I remember my feeling of alienation as I entered that room and saw what was on the walls, who was on them, paintings of old white men, former vice-chancellors; they were modern in style but not content. I remember women coming around in uniforms serving tea and cake. But what really stood out was how the secretary and the chair of the board engaged in sexual innuendo throughout the meeting. I remember feeling shocked by how everyone else seemed to be laughing along.

My feminist bubble had burst. Our complaint biographies can include moments like this, when reality intrudes and illusions shatter. We do not always make complaints at those moments, which is why our complaint biographies include the times we don't complain.

You can have a complaint without making one.

Even to indicate you might complain within an institution is to receive many messages from it that tell you about it. Remember Darcy's experience: She decided not to complain because she was told by the institution, or at least those responsible for administering complaints, that the professor who was harassing her would be protected (and she would not). She met a set of beliefs I call *institutional fatalism*, assertions that what institutions *are* is what they *will be* (institutions will be institutions!). She was told there was no point in complaining given the person she was complaining about was "well loved." To be told "institutions will be institutions" is to be told who they will and will not love, who they will and will not protect. Institutional fatalism sometimes combines with gender fatalism: "Boys will be boys." Darcy also said she didn't complain formally about her supervisor because it would most likely become "a note in his file." Were he to be freed from any consequences of the complaint, she thought she would be the one to suffer them.

I suspect it is not so much that senior managers or administrators believe institutions cannot change but that they want other people to believe it, or at least to act as if they do. And the people they want to believe it are the very people who act as if they don't. That is why the people who are more likely to complain are also more likely to know about institutional fatalism. Emma, a woman of color, shared her knowledge of institutions with me. Explaining why she didn't complain about the sexism and racism she experienced in her department, she said, "There's an agreement between people not to rock the boat. People would talk about the institution as a kind of legacy project and would imply that you just didn't understand how the institution was formed. The implication was that you have to be respectful of how this place was organized and what its traditions were, essentially." This expression, "rocking the boat," came up earlier in warnings not to complain. That phrase is used here to imply agreement among members of an institution to treat it as a legacy project.

The institutional culture is that you do not complain about the institutional culture.

To become part of the institution is to take up the task of protecting it *from* complaint and sometimes *by* complaint. There are, of course, many different kinds of institutions. At one level, the term is used simply to denote scale: An institution can refer to a large and important organization (so, if you work for a bank, you are part of a financial institution).¹ Institutions are how we preserve the past, not only in a story we tell of “how the institution was formed” but by our conduct, being “respectful of how this place was organized.” When we use the term *institutions*, we are not just pointing to traditions but to the act of incorporating them, how we learn to fit in or to do things in the right way. Many of the rules that govern behavior are not written down in instruction manuals but shared by word of mouth or through imitation or suggestion. Becoming part of an institution can reference the time it takes to say yes to its demands, until it becomes almost automatic to do so. That’s why, when complaints teach us about the nature of institutions, they are teaching us how social forms persist over time: Those who say yes are more likely to progress.

That *yes* has a history, even when it is automatic, or especially when it is. Historian Timothy Snyder opens his important book *On Tyranny* with an instruction, “Do not obey in advance.” He suggests that citizens who obey in advance of an order, a phenomenon he calls “anticipatory obedience,” are “teaching power what it can do.” Disobedience is indeed what we need in the face of the rapid rise of authoritarianism, the hard-to-check abuses of power by oligarchs and patriarchs, the increasing hostility toward, and scapegoating of, minorities.

Snyder’s second instruction is to “defend institutions.”² Snyder is pointing to how institutions should function to prevent power from being concentrated in one person or party; when tyrants get into power through demo-

cratic institutions, they seek to destroy those institutions as quickly as possible. In this part of the book, I show how many institutions function to teach people to obey, to say yes in advance of an order, not least because of how they reward compliance. Using Snyder's logic, institutions would then be sowing the seeds of their own destruction, creating citizens ill-equipped to fight for them by fighting back against those who seize power by illegitimate means. Institutions that reward compliance themselves become more compliant, less willing or able to stand up to tyranny.

The word *obedience* derives from ear; to obey is to give your ear to the law or to the tyrant who suspends the law by replacing it with his own will. A feminist ear might be how we hear the instructions by refusing to follow them; hearing with defiance, not compliance. The data of complaint is generated because people can and do defy the instructions, saying no to institutions, despite being told that there is no point in doing so. This data is also a series of snapshots of institutional resistance to change. If the title of this part of the book gives the impression that I am going to share some rather more positive stories about complaints, how they succeed in changing institutions, that is not what I am doing. There is nevertheless something positive in these stories. Even when complaints do not succeed in a simple or straightforward way, they teach us that institutions can and do change. And so, most importantly, they help reveal that institutional fatalism is a lie.

To build a new world we need to dismantle the existing one. In saying no, or by saying it, we search for an alternative. *We complain for a more just world.* That *for* matters. We are more used to speaking of complaining *about* something or *against* it. Complaining *for* means we have to work against something to bring something else about.

The term *world-building* is most often used with reference to speculative fiction, the imaginative creation of alternative worlds. My emphasis in this part of the book is different but related. The practical effort to dismantle structures is how we grasp the possibility of alternatives. We have to fight to make things possible, including, in some cases, ourselves. Queer theorist Jack Halberstam offers a powerful critique of the utopian impulse of world-making. Rather than focusing on the future as the space of hope, he considers institutions that are collapsing and finds amid the ruins a queer potential. Halberstam quotes from the Black lesbian artist Beverley Buchanan:

My interest in walls involves the concept of urban walls when they are in various stages of decay, walls as part of a landscape. Often, when buildings are in a state of demolition—one or two structural pieces (Frustula) stand out that otherwise, never would have been “created.” This state of demolition presents a new type of “artificial” structural system piece that by itself (its undemolished state) would not exist. These “discards” or piles of rubble can be pulled together to form new systems. These new systems are very personal statements to me. They are inspired by urban ruins but are created “in my own image” by me, in concrete and painted with dark paint. Deceptively, they appear to be black. (One of my dreams: to place fragments in tall grass where a house once stood but where, now, only the chimney bricks remain.)¹

When the walls collapse, they can become part of a different landscape. What is discarded as rubble can amount to something else. When we encounter walls, the doors, in making complaints, they seem to be functioning rather well. They hold up. But when you make complaints within institutions, you often end up involved in the

effort to change them, to stop them from working. The very effort to stop the doors and the walls from working is how we create a different landscape.

In *No Is Not Enough*, author and activist Naomi Klein argues that “the firmest of nos has to be accompanied by a bold and forward-looking yes.”² I understand my argument in *No!* as complementing rather than contradicting Klein’s. We have to repeat *no* because of resistance to hearing it. When I used to give talks on racism, I would hear a *but* typically turned into a question: “But what can white people do?” Another question was “But what about resistance?” That latter question was repeated enough times for me to wonder whether the desire for resistance was itself a resistance to hearing about racism. People want to pass over a *no* quickly. We have to work to stop *no* being passed over or blocked or stopped. *No* is not just what we say; *no* is what we do. We learn what it will take to build alternatives from our refusal to reproduce more of the same.

We have been hearing of many defenses against institutional change; *anti-woke* is just the latest version. It is not just some complaints that are blocked but the messages they contain, what I call **killjoy truths**. There are some very clear messages, we could even call them instructions: Stop confusing brilliance with bullying! Or confusing collectivity with compliance! Stop protecting abusers! Or covering up complaints! Consider, for example, the resignation of Archbishop Justin Welby in 2024 after the publication of a 253-page report into child abuse perpetrated by John Smyth. Religious studies scholar Linda Woodhead argued that his resignation would or should lead to an “existential crisis” for the Church: “It’s been a very, very long time coming, like lots of crises,” she said, “but this is a critical moment.”³ We need institutions to have existential crises. Mostly, however, it is those who complain who end up having them.

Our work becomes to cause a crisis in the system. Changing the system can be our life’s work. We could ask, who can afford to make working to change the system their life’s work? We could ask, who can afford not to?

We've heard already from people who complained, even though they could ill afford to, because they could *not* afford for the conditions in which they were living or working *not* to change. Nevertheless, it is still worth thinking about the resources needed for complaint as part of our justice work. I certainly know of people who complained because they had the resources to do so (and by resources, I don't just mean money, but time and skills). Some people complain precisely because they are aware other people can't. Some people use their resources to help other people complain.

Behind the perception of the complainer-as-privileged lurks an assumption that principles are only for those who can afford them. And yet, and I think we know this, so many people who can afford principles don't have them. We have been hearing how people are rewarded by institutions for giving up principles. I doubt very much that radical change is going to happen because of the actions of those who can most afford to have principles. Those who can most afford principles might, after all, have most to lose from radical change. So, our question might be not *who* can afford to fight for change but *how* can we afford to fight for change. Thinking about complaint as activism and as a queer method is another way of reflecting on the possibility of radical change not as simply or only deriving from principled action but as a practical and collective task.